THE ONE THING KIRAN MAZUMDAR-SHAW RECALLS from 1978, when she was trying to hire her first set of recruits at Biocon, is how candidates would walk into the garage-office of her home in Bengaluru's Koramangala and want to meet the managing director. On discovering that the 'chit of a girl' sitting behind the desk was the one wanting to hire them, many were plainly disappointed, others even felt cheated. "Today, we have created a global-scale biotech company with very high-end research and scientific capabilities, and which has over 15,000 scientists and engineers."

Her career in biotech, however, is just one part of Kiran's multi-faceted personality. In 2019, she co-founded the start-up Immuneel along with renowned cancer physician Siddhartha Mukherjee to enable access to cell-based immunotherapies for cancer patients in India. She's on the board of numerous global institutions, including the US-based Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center and the Massachusetts Institute of Technology.

Last year, Biocon Biologics acquired the global biosimilars business of the firm's US-based partner Viatris Inc. for $3.34 billion. "I'm trying to create a global leader in biosimilars," says Kiran. "It's very ambitious and I know I'll try very hard to be among the top three, if not at the top."

ACCOMPLISHMENT

After building a biotech ecosystem in the country, she is now trying to take the global lead in biosimilars



Starting out, her biggest challenges were establishing credibility and accessing capital, given the stereotypes about women, that they look for safety, not risk, and thus make poor businesspeople. She has proved them wrong on every count. For instance, not many know that the sprawling 20-acre campus that is the current Biocon corporate headquarters on the outskirts of Bengaluru was once a remote plot of land that Kiran picked up in a distress sale. Then, when she pivoted to biopharmaceuticals, she was advised to focus on pharmaceuticals like everybody else. "I said, well, that's my strength. I don't want to be a me-too company." Taking a different approach in business meant a long gestation period, but the rewards were 'well worth it'. "What makes me feel very fulfilled and proud is that I was able to build an ecosystem in biotech, which led to other companies in the sector." The biotech sector in India is slated to grow to $500 bn by 2047, she points out.

Her entrepreneurial genes come from her mother, says Kiran. "She was 70 when she started a drycleaning business and ran it for 20 years," she says. Her father, the head brewmaster at United Breweries, gave her wings, encouraging her to pursue anything she wanted. Philanthropy too. "He'd always say money is not to be splashed around, it is to make a difference to society," she says.

As a philanthropist, Kiran is passionate about supporting science, research and education. Also about improving Bengaluru, the city she grew up in, via the civic action group Bangalore Political Action Committee (BPAC), Science Gallery and the Museum of Art and Photography. A lover of art, Biocon's offices have a thousand artworks on their walls—all handpicked by her. She also played golf for many years, a game she enjoyed greatly with her husband, the late John Shaw. ■

–Ajay Sukumaran

GOLDEN TIP

"There are no shortcuts. If you really want to build an enduring entrepreneurial company, you have to be patient. Use your capital wisely"

OFFBEAT PURSUIT

Snorkelling. She loves to go to the Maldives or Phuket. She also likes holidays where she can go on a small boat, jump into the sea, see fish